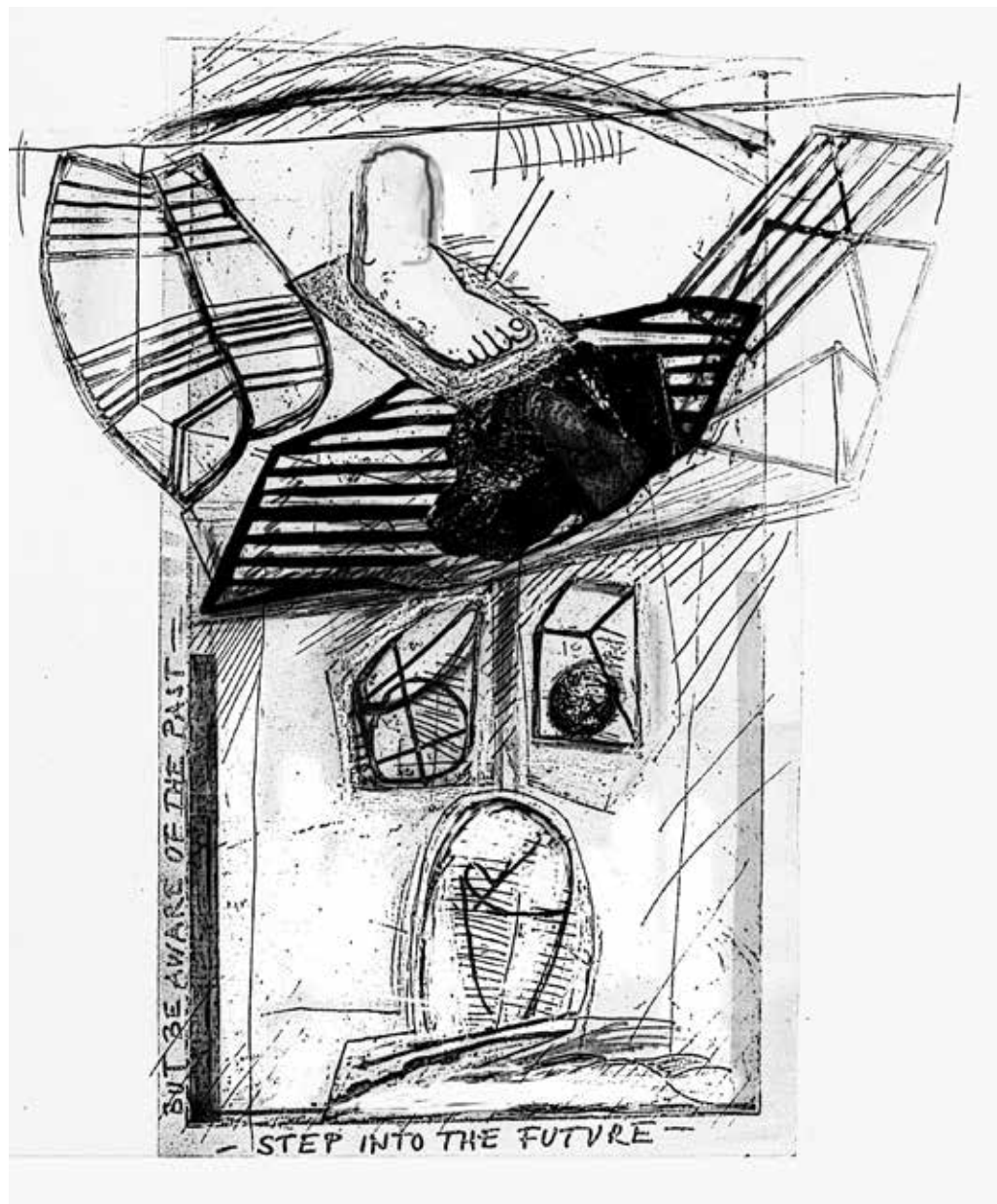


Agathe Sorel

FROM DARKNESS TO HOPE



Agathe Sorel, *Step into The Future but be aware of the past*, coloured plastic engraving, 1986

Volume One

Agathe Sorel

FROM DARKNESS TO HOPE

Step into the Future
but be aware of the Past

Limited edition
Studio of Contemporary Art

Note to the reader

Throughout the text there are references to various websites which will give a broader understanding of the topics discussed.

A list of these websites is available on Agathe's website,

www.agathesorel.co.uk

on the memoirs page, and are arranged in chapter order according to the text of the book.

For ease of use we recommend that you use the website while reading this book.

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Agathe Sorel

Agathe Sorel was born in 1935 in Budapest. She and her parents escaped deportation during the Second World War as a result of the intervention of Raoul Wallenberg. She studied at the Academy of Applied Arts and the Institute of Fine Arts in Budapest before fleeing to England during the 1956 Hungarian Uprising. She settled in London where she studied at Camberwell School of Arts and Crafts. In 1958, she was awarded a Gulbenkian scholarship which allowed her to live in Paris for two years, where she studied etching with S.W. Hayter at Atelier 17. On her return to London, she set up her own studio in Fulham where she became well-known for her prints and Perspex sculptures.

Sorel taught for many years at Camberwell School of Arts, Maidstone College and Goldsmith's College. She has had solo exhibitions at galleries around the world and her work has been acquired by a number of private and public collections including, in this country, Tate, the British Museum, the Victoria & Albert Museum, the Arts Council of England, the British Library, the Ashmolean Museum, Oxford and the Fitzwilliam Museum, Cambridge. She has travelled extensively in the USA where her work can be found in collections including the Philadelphia Museum, the Library of Congress, Washington, New York Public Library, the Art Institute of Chicago, the Smithsonian Institute, Washington and the Museum of Fine Arts, Boston. She was a founding member of the Printmakers Council and presently is on the Council of the Royal Watercolour Society, and a member of the Royal Society of Printmakers. Agathe Sorel lives in London with her husband, the artist Gabor Sitkey.

Foreword by Peter Hacker

Agathe Sorel is an artist, adventurer, free spirit and free thinker. She should be an inspiration to us all. She was born in Hungary in 1935, and escaped the holocaust together with her parents by the skin of their teeth. The Nazi's were followed by the home-bred Hungarian Arrow Cross murderous antisemitic thugs, and from these too Agathe escaped. Then followed eleven years of oppressive Communist rule, which she also managed to survive. She escaped to the West in 1956, since when she has developed her remarkable talents and skills in art across five continents, always looking for fresh forms of expression and inventing new media of representation. She has made distinguished contributions to painting sculpture, and to printmaking, and she has broken down the boundaries between art forms with her engraved, coloured plastic sculptures using shadows produced by both electric and natural light. Her political courage as a child and young girl are matched by her artistic and intellectual integrity as an adult and later as a mature artist. She has never hesitated to challenge orthodoxy, and never been tempted to succumb to alien pressures to conform.

At the age of 84 Agathe has written a two volume history not only of her own life, but of the lives of her family and friends who shared the fate of central European Jewry in the years of the horrors of the German Reich, and of her friends who suffered and often gave their lives in the struggle for liberty against Soviet oppression.

The first volume of this memoir, *From Darkness to Hope*, covers the life of her family from the times of her grandparents to 1956, as well as the lives of her fellow students at the Budapest Academy of Applied Art and at the Institute of Fine Arts in Budapest. This makes for sombre reading. Most of the members of her family were slaughtered and so too were many of her childhood friends. She and her parents escaped only through the good fortune of the heroic Raoul Wallenberg. She tells her tale concisely, in short but compelling chapters, illustrated by contemporary family photographs, and by her own collages, drawings and paintings. She rarely comments on the horrific events she recounts, but lets the bare facts speak for themselves. Her story is riveting, but deeply depressing. She decided to tell it for her grandchildren, but also for the public in general lest it be forgotten, a fear that is patently warranted today, as the far right is revived both on the continent, in the UK and in the USA and as the evils of

antisemitism flourish yet again. She quotes the powerful remark of Milan Kundera: 'The struggle of men against power is a struggle of memory against forgetting'.

The second volume, entitled *Projections in Space and Time*, relates Agathe's life from her arrival in England in 1956 until the present. It is a tale of an avant garde artist living through the years of artistic revolution and innovation of the post-war years and into the twenty-first century. She witnessed and participated in the greatest transformations of art in modern history, and met and often came to know many of the greatest artists of the times. Her descriptions of many of the artists she knew are fascinating. So too are her descriptions of the remarkable developments of her own art as she experimented constantly with new materials and new methods.

Shortly after her arrival in Britain she was awarded a place at Camberwell School of Arts and Crafts, where she was privileged to be taught by Michael Rothenstein, who helped her develop her skills at intaglio printmaking. In 1961, she was elected to a prestigious Gulbenkian Scholarship, which not only enabled her to travel throughout western Europe, but also made it possible for her to attend Atelier 17 in Paris, where she had the good fortune to work with Bill Hayter, the finest intaglio experimental printmaker of his times. Of course, she met many of the great postwar printmakers at Atelier 17. In 1966, by now having established a reputation as an exciting young artist, she was awarded a Churchill Fellowship to Mexico and the USA, where she travelled extensively, meeting many avant garde artists and learning new techniques.

On her return, she set up her own studio, and in subsequent years held numerous successful shows of her work. Ever eager to experiment, she seized upon the possibilities of a new material, perspex, to create three dimensional engraving combined with complex lighting and movement. With the invention of photocopying, Agathe immediately started to explore the possibilities of photocopying a wide variety of three dimensional objects to yield amazing distortions that can be used in printmaking and collage.

In 1973, Agathe and her husband, Gabor Sitkey purchased a tumbled down cottage on Lanzarote, the Canary Island saved from the curses of modern development by the genius of César Manrique. Gradually, over the next years, they made their ruin into a habitable home. The island not only enabled her to escape city life in London, and to enjoy that rarest of modern commodities, silence, it also provided wonderful inspiration for her ventures into the wonders of the *livres d'artiste*.

Her collaged character studies of the artists she has known are fascinating, her tales of their often tragic lives sad but informative. Most inspiring are her stories of her own development of new techniques and new forms of expression. Her enthusiasm is wonderful, and her creative drive enviable. Her two volumes of memoirs exemplify the triumph of the human spirit over adversity.

Dedication

I dedicate my memoirs to my two grandchildren
Anoushka and Dylan Sitkey in order that they might
learn from my experience and know something of
the history of our family.

*The struggle of men against power is a struggle of memory
against forgetting.*

*When the strong were too weak to hurt the weak, the weak
had to be strong enough to leave.*

Milan Kundera

Life is a struggle and man's end is the struggle itself

Imre Madách 1861 from the *Tragedy of Man*

Full length cartoon film by Marcell Jankovics

<https://youtu.be/6vCoo42Ut5g>

This is not free but could be hired for £2.49

Trailers:

<https://youtu.be/oeSdOPcHum8>

<https://youtu.be/6a4PlhNsdS4>

<https://youtu.be/PsLnRVXvIW0>

Introduction

When I was a child, I wrote a diary on small strips of paper. It was among my most treasured possessions. I never talked about it. It was one of the few things I brought with me when we fled to England after the Hungarian uprising in 1956 and I tried to translate it despite my rather basic and inadequate English.

On these scraps of paper, I described the extraordinary coincidences that led to the survival of my family during the Holocaust and the Russian occupation immediately after.

The diary started on the 15th March 1943, when I was not yet 8 years old and I finished compiling it after the 13th February 1945 when Hungary was liberated by the Soviet forces, aided by bombing of pinpoint accuracy by the Allied powers.

A childhood friend, a professional translator whose help I sought, lost my only copy when she moved house and I never forgave either her or her husband. We did not speak for many years.

Time passed, memories resurfaced and revived in my mind, particularly during recent Holocaust commemorations. A child's vivid and personal reminiscences were augmented by research and experiences of others in similar circumstances. I started to question why so many people were keeping quiet about the greatest crimes against humanity in history.

I had never even told my husband about my experiences before I undertook writing these memoirs. My cousin George's wife Anne, when she was researching our family history on the Internet, wondered why so many relatives changed their names. She had no idea of our Jewish origin. My cousin George, who was educated by the Jesuits as a day boy in Milan between 1935 and 1939, became deeply religious and converted to Catholicism. He too never told her of the family's history, maybe he did not even know about it as a child; it was certainly safer this way when prejudice still existed¹.

I think the new generation should know, bear up to the gruesome details, and face the facts, so they are prepared should such events ever happen again. Young relatives and friends are now interested in this period of history. They want to know.

The first part of these memoirs is based on the diaries and correspondence of three generations of my family. They also show

¹ I have come to understand since that the Jesuits were involved in resistance to the Nazis. 152 Jesuits were killed by the Nazis but they succeeded in saving many Jewish lives

the little understood social history of Yugoslavia, Transylvania and Hungary covering almost two centuries.

I added a lot of detail, to describe the life style and social history in those years, as these would be quite unfamiliar to the younger generation; I also found that the devil is in the detail when evoking personal and emotional involvement by the readers. I did not want to sanitize any of the events or to fictionalize them. Real life is sometimes more dramatic than fiction. The events described here might be horrible and frightening, but they must be remembered.

When I finished the first draft of these memoirs, I found much additional material in an abandoned and forgotten drawer of my desk. It contained poignant letters, dramatic and haunting photographs, and contemporary newspaper articles from World War I, mostly from my father's family.

I also found extensive correspondence and advice from my teacher and mentor Margit Graber, a long letter from my boyfriend Sándor Lévai, which I had never read and cannot now respond to as he has been dead for 20 years. I still have to come to terms with this and find out the details of what he was writing about, which is difficult as most of the participants are now dead or very old.

I then focus on my own memories of the Holocaust, the end of World War II and the Russian occupation of Hungary in 1956. Some of this was written when I was 9 years old, the rest as a teenager and later a student and young adult.

Nevertheless, I hope the narrative will show the emergence of hope and fulfilment both as an artist and as a mother. Although my husband Gabor and I travelled widely and could have settled anywhere, we came back to England time and time again as we experienced kindness and freedom to live the way we wanted. This does not mean that things were always easy.

In 1961, we became British citizens and could travel, work and live without restrictions; I received the Gulbenkian Scholarship and other help from the same foundation to set up my studio and exhibit worldwide. In 1966-67 I won a Churchill fellowship to travel and work in the USA and Mexico.

In 1970 my son was born, a real British citizen, who unfortunately never learnt Hungarian. My parents were alas no longer alive to enjoy him. We fought very hard to give him a good education, but it was a worthwhile struggle. He won a scholarship to Cambridge in engineering and is now a director of an American IT company. He was lucky enough to marry the love of his life, Alleyna, a consultant microbiologist and we now have two lovely grandchildren. I hope this memoir will be valuable when they grow up.



An original print incorporating family photo of Lala Mama, Moci papa and Magda on the terrace, the Thoman Villa in Vrbas, family letters and a cushion from my mother's dowry. On the right, a portrait of Lola

Chapter 1: My Family

Vrbas

My maternal grandparents lived in Vrbas, which was, before 1914, part of the Austro-Hungarian Empire, but is now in Serbia.

My mother and I spent our summer vacations in their beautiful house, still named Villa Thomán after my grandmother's second husband. The house was surrounded by a lush and romantic garden. They also had some land, a vineyard, a farmhouse, horses and a carriage. It was a truly magical place for a small child.

Vrbas was then a one street village, with virtually no traffic apart from a few horse-drawn carriages and farm carts. The cows were taken out to pasture in the morning, but came home all by themselves in the evening, each returning to their stalls. The news was read out at midday by a drummer on two or three street corners. These were Town Hall employees in smart uniforms, who informed us of both national and world events. A Town Hall official read the international papers arriving in the morning post and was then responsible for writing out the text.

A shipping canal went through the village. It connected two major rivers, the Danube and the Tisza, thereby watering the nearby fertile land and enabling the shipping of grain and other farm produce to the North.

This was a great commercial asset to the area and people with entrepreneurial spirit prospered.

The population came from a mixture of ethnic backgrounds and the children, who went to school and played peacefully together in the street, all spoke Hungarian, German and Serbian.

The Villa Thomán

My grandparents' house was rather grand for such a small village. It had been designed by a leading Hungarian architect from Budapest in the style known as art nouveau or Jugendstil. It had a classical portico with a wide spiral staircase, leading to a huge reception hall with parquet floors. There were frieze panels in the style of Böcklin² around the ceiling, with nude figures of nymphs cavorting with Pan in a shallow stream. This painting was covered

**My grandparents'
house in Vrbas**



up with white paint during the war and now it is painted black as it is probably unsuitable for the insurance company which now has its offices there. The entrance hall led into a large dining room. There were several bedrooms and a very modern bathroom for its time.

The house was built by my Grandfather Adolf not far from the new business he just joined. The land he bought had an ordinary, perfectly habitable house on it, but typically, he pulled it down to build the present extraordinary architectural gem. It is now occupied by the afore-mentioned insurance company and it seems to be the only tourist attraction in an otherwise run-down village. It figures on postcards, posters and tourist information leaflets about the area.

My Grandfather Adolf Biro

My grandfather, Adolf Biro, came from a poor Jewish family. When his mother died, he was 13 years old and his father could no longer support him and send him to school.

He was a clever boy, a mathematical genius in fact, who could perform complicated calculations in his head. He was sent to a local firm to work as an accountant or clerk. He was so small at the time

2 Arnold Böcklin (1827-1901) was a Swiss Symbolist painter

15 November 1938
1 September 1939
3 September 1939

mination of Jews;
Jered at the camp

All Jewish pupils expelled from German schools
War started by Germany invading Poland
UK and France declare war on Germany

9 - 10 November

15 November 1938

Jewish pogrom in Germany,
agogues destroyed; 7,500 Jewish
to concentration camps (Dachau,

that he needed a special foot stool to stand on to reach his desk. Nevertheless, he was appreciated not only for his bookkeeping but also for his growing business acumen and managerial skills. He had the chance to read, educate himself and travel on business trips to larger regional towns, to Italy and to Austria.

When he was 18 years old he was encouraged to join a similar, but much larger business, where he became a partner. He married the daughter of the owner, my grandmother Laura Singer in what appears to have been almost an arranged marriage, so keen was his boss to assure his stake in the business.

He transformed an ordinary farm produce shop dealing in grain, wine and groceries to a large regional wholesale operation, quadrupling the profits in a short time. He also began to sell exotic art objects, Persian rugs, ceramics, rare books and prints. He was so successful he became the largest tax payer in the county.

Adolf died of complications brought on by diphtheria, caught on a grain buying trip, when he was only 38 years old. He was treated by the best specialists in a sanatorium near Vienna, but to no avail. My mother and her older sister Klári were just 14 and 15 years of age.

My Grandmother Laura Biro 1885-1964

The house was run by my grandmother Lala Mama who raised housekeeping to a great art.

She had a sunny and warm disposition. People called her Trallala Mama because she was always so joyful. She was very popular and adored by her two daughters, to whom she remained very close throughout her life.

Grandmother Lala
Mama holding me. She
was very popular and
was enlisted during the
First World War by the
Red Cross



During the First World War, the wounded were treated and operated on in schools. Young women were enlisted by the Red Cross to assist the doctors.

Lala was the only one who did not faint at the site of amputations and other operations and became chief theatre nurse.

Later the fighting got so near the village that the family decided to flee and left the area for Budapest, where they felt safer. They stayed in a hotel for nine months, risking the dangerous journey home only when things looked to have settled. However, the whole area was in turmoil for years after the creation of the new country of Yugoslavia and the county they lived in, Bánát, was separated from Hungary.

Lala was painted by the renowned Hungarian portraitist Philip de Laszlo³ who visited the house several times; he must have been rather taken by her warmth and hospitality. He painted her under strict instructions to make her look much slimmer than she was. The result, a fine portrait, hung in our home in Budapest for many years. I was able to reclaim it after we fled from the revolution and it now hangs in my study.

Lala was a great cook and employed several women to help her prepare marvellous and elaborate meals. Most of the recipes in my mother's hand-written cook book came from her mother. The house had to be kept spick and span. The parquet flooring was waxed and polished regularly by a maid who rubbed the floor with a cloth under her feet, cursing and swearing as she progressed. But Lala did not care as long as the job was done to perfection. The large oriental rugs were frequently taken out onto the terrace to be brushed and beaten with canes to get rid of the dust as, of course, vacuum cleaners had not yet been invented.

Lala had silver cutlery engraved with her initials in the traditional style, though more modern designs were used for the dowries of her two daughters, Magda and Klári. I still have one of these modern sets today. Dozens of seamstresses were employed to complete the dowries for the daughters anticipating their forthcoming

³ László was actually born into a humble Jewish family in Budapest, his parents being a tailor and seamstress. After studying in art in Budapest, Munich and Paris, he won a Grand Gold Medal at the Paris International Exhibition in 1900 for a portrait of Pope Leo XIII. In the same year, he married Lucy Guinness, a member of the banking branch of the Guinness family whom he had first met in Munich in 1892. He eventually took British citizenship and had a very successful career as a society portrait painter, painting amongst others the Queen and the Queen Mother. For more information, see Philip de László: *Life and Art Hardcover* by Duff Hart-Davis and Caroline Corbeau, Yale University Press 2010

marriages. The bedding and other linen was embroidered using the pull thread technique fashionable at the time. Several of these items still exist after two world wars, revolution and emigration.

Lala remarried, to Miklós Thomán a distant cousin recently retired from the army. He was a grain merchant living in Budapest, who wanted to move to Bácska to exploit commercial possibilities. They married after a long courtship and moved into the house, which became known as the Thomán Villa even though he had nothing to do with its creation.

Lala Mama lived much of her life in luxury but had the strength of character to survive during difficult times. She experienced many terrible events through the two wars. She had to escape from her home twice, taking just a small rucksack with her as the house was occupied first by Nazis and then by Communists. Our beautiful villa was confiscated by the state and returned to the family several times. She survived to see her grandson happily married

Agathe Sorel, *Fumee*,
line engraving, 1961





Agathe Sorel, *Après la Moissin*, line engraving, 1959

to his wonderful wife Anne, and to see her three granddaughters growing up, graduating and getting married.

I stayed close to my grandmother all my life. I remember that in the early 1960s she visited my husband and me in our new home in London in Irene Road, Fulham. We took her to parks, museums and other places of interest. I remember our visit to Chiswick House was particularly successful.

She looked at my artwork, which was very experimental and modern. I did not expect her to understand; indeed, at the time my work was controversial in the art world, and especially in England, in spite of the many exhibitions I had held and the fact that some works had been acquired for museums.

She examined the patterns on the bark of a tree and decided that this was modern art. She definitely had a feel and understanding for abstract art.

It was in a way fortunate that she died when she did. My mother Magda survived her by just a matter of weeks before succumbing to cancer of the liver at the age of just 56.

My Step-Grandfather Miklós Thomán

I found my step-grandfather, whom we called Moci Papa, rather stiff and uncommunicative. My cousin George was his favourite and he played with him as if he was his own child. I appreciate, however,

that he did a lot of good to maintain the house and estate in very harsh political circumstances during and after the First World War.

Once he took me with him to a farm and vineyard. The horses were harnessed and the carriage prepared and we drove along a dusty and bumpy road. He took me down to the wine cellars and showed me the large barrels stored there. He was careful not to repeat the mistake made with my mother who was taken down there as a child. She passed out from the fumes and had to be rushed to hospital. I instead had to wait at top of the stairs in the open air until it was declared safe to descend.

I was given a sweet little duckling to take home. It died shortly afterwards and I was inconsolable. We buried it in the garden in a shoebox.

After the war, investments held in foreign banks became valueless. However, Moci Papa found a small window of opportunity when he bribed an official and accessed some of the funds. He managed to convert them to the local currency, the Dinar. He had to reinvest the money the same day, otherwise the money would have lost its value.

So Moci Papa did just that. He bought an apartment house of 18 flats in Budapest the very same day. One of these became our home and we lived there until the early 1950s (with the exception of the Holocaust years), when it was confiscated from us by the communist regime. We did not receive any form of compensation.

Lala was devoted to Moci to the end and was devastated when he died.

My Paternal Grandparents

I hardly knew my paternal grandparents, but when I was two years old, I was taken to visit them in Nagyvárad. This was part of the Austro-Hungarian Empire until 1918, but then became part of Romania and is known in Romanian as Oradea. It was returned to Hungary briefly during World War II. My only memory of the visit was of their dining room with its large table covered with white lace tablecloth and a vitrine with fascinating glass figurines. Alas, I never saw them again.

My grandmother was the headmistress of a school which was very successful; she received an elaborate gold rosette in recognition of her work from Emperor Franz Josef who was very interested in education. This was no doubt also a political gesture, to keep Transylvania within the Empire.

I recently learnt from a newspaper article I found amongst her letters, that she had the innovative idea of starting an industrial

apprentice school, where half the time the students learned traditional academic subjects and the other half was spent learning a trade, like carpentry, metal work or building work. The Emperor Francis Josef was a keen carpenter and supported this initiative.

There was a portrait of my grandmother wearing her cross, painted by her husband, a handsome art teacher in her school. The portrait hung in my father's consulting room, together with a charcoal self-portrait of my grandfather, in the style of Raphael.

My Father Gyula Szüts

My father Gyula Szüts was 16 years older than my mother. They met in Vienna. He was by then a well-established consultant of neurology in a leading hospital in Budapest. He also had a degree in music; he played the violin and viola and organised chamber music concerts in his home throughout his life.

His background was unusual. He came from a family of teachers and educators. Both his mother and grandmother were teachers and his mother, as I have mentioned, had married a good looking, somewhat younger art teacher from her school.

Correspondence shows that my father did not go to the industrial college that his mother ran, but to his grandmother's much more academic establishment. He wanted to be a doctor. He seemed to have been much closer to his grandmother than his mother and confided his fears and problems to her. He would have to take his medical degree in Budapest, where standards were much higher, where intellectual life was much more stimulating, not only in science and medicine, but in the arts as well. There one could meet interesting and really outstanding people. There were five Nobel Prize winners and outstanding economists, photographers, filmmakers and artists amongst them, most of whom emigrated to France or the USA when the first anti-Jewish laws came out.

It was not easy for a penniless provincial Jewish student to join this company, to attend university and the Academy of Music in particular. His studies were interrupted by the First World War, during which he served as a medical orderly which benefited him as he did not have to pay for the remainder of his studies. Nevertheless, at the end of the war, things became more difficult for Jewish students. In 1920, the Numerus Clausus policy was introduced in Hungary. Often seen as the first Anti-Jewish Act of twentieth century Europe, its aim was to restrict the number of Jews attending university to 6%, which was their proportion in Hungary at that time; the rate of Jewish students was approximately 15% in the 1910s.

My father



My father Gyula Szücs a young doctor 1919



and a third year medical student in the army 1917

First view of my son born 1970



My father confessed to his grandmother in his many letters home that he no longer had faith and did not consider himself to be a Jew; I reproduce an excerpt from one of these letters, sent whilst he was serving in the army.

New Year's Eve c.1916

Dear Granny and my dearest parents

I would have liked to imagine myself on a mild September day on your sofa and do a little ledger of my hopes, yearnings and ambitions, but it is hardly possible in a cold winter night, when I am despondent or downcast, when I can only say "My God, will I have the strength?"

This "My God" would be an encouraging or intoxicating thought for a religious person, which I no longer am, but I want to live as I am still young; but indeed, will I have the strength?

These are my thoughts and I wish you all a Happy New Year

Love and lots of kisses, Gyula

He would have liked to remain observant but decided he was agnostic. He also admitted that he was often hungry and suffered from the cold. He wrote letters home in which he wondered if he would have the force to overcome all these vicissitudes. He was sent a warm winter coat and a woollen blanket, but money was more difficult to send out of the country. I believe his cousins Imre Szirmai, a well-known actor and Aladár Bayer helped him for a while, but he also had to take on part-time jobs during his studies as university education was not free.

He was 4th year medical student, when he was drafted into the army as a medical orderly in World War 1, whilst his younger brother Imre served as an infantry officer. Imre was fatally wounded in battle and died later in a camp for prisoners of war. His parents were obviously distressed and urged Gyula to return home and take a job as a doctor in one of the nearby towns, get married and have children.

This was obviously not on the cards for my father; having got so far, he wanted to go all the way and establish himself in Budapest. His results and scientific research were excellent and he found employment in the Rokus, one of the biggest hospitals in Budapest, where he specialized in neurology. He was also able to put down a deposit for a large flat in the central square of Liszt Ferenc Tér no. 4 where he also planned to have his private surgery.

He was in Vienna in 1920 where he underwent psychoanalysis by Sándor Ferenczi⁴, an associate of Sigmund Freud⁵ as he wanted to add to his qualifications and pursue a career both as a neurologist and a psychoanalyst simultaneously. He was a slight, fair haired man with piercing blue eyes, with a wonderful sense of humour and absolutely no small talk.

He met my mother on the ski slopes near Vienna; he was very impressed by her sportsmanship as well as her intellect and they were shortly married to everyone's great relief.

In fact, the marriage did not work out and they divorced. They were to marry and divorce again during war time but throughout, they remained close friends, with great regard for each other.

The reasons for the first divorce were pretty obvious. My father was, at the time of their marriage, an established doctor and very busy man. He worked at the hospital as a Neurology Consultant in the mornings, came home for lunch and after a short siesta started to see his private patients as a psychoanalyst in the afternoon.

He also did research and wrote books and articles on both subjects as well as practising the violin or the viola, so as not to remain out of step with the professional musicians (most of them patients) in his chamber ensemble. He finished rather late and, after dinner, went for a long walk, on which later on I would often accompany him.

It is hard to see how my parents managed to meet and spend time together. My mother had no role as a home maker or companion /helper; all these roles were already filled. The housekeeper answered the phone, passed on messages and acted as an informal receptionist as well as shopping, cooking and cleaning.

My mother did her best to bring me up when they divorced, but between my father and I there was a unique bond, surpassing everything in our lives.

He sacrificed everything, when he selflessly arranged for an ambulance to take us abroad, a sacrifice, which later resulted in his untimely death from a heart attack aged 64.

My Mother, Magda Biro

My mother was slim, sporty, highly intelligent and motivated.

⁴ Sándor Ferenczi (1873-1933) was a Hungarian psychoanalyst of Jewish origin. For more information, visit <https://www.sandorferenczi.org>

⁵ Sigmund Freud (1856-1939) was an Austrian-Jewish neurologist and the founder of psychoanalysis. He was forced by the rise of Nazism to flee Vienna and came to London in 1939



Left: Béla Balázs, both Hilda and Balazs were first cousins of my father quite close relatives. He wanted to help Hilda by sending me to English and French conversation lessons twice a week. Turned out to be quite useful in the end.



Right: the renowned composer Béla Bartók with whom Balázs collaborated on Bluebeard's Castle

Inspired by the career and achievements of Madame Curie, she wanted to be a research scientist, but her parents considered this would be unsuitable for a girl and also make her unmarriedable. This was because the degree course and post graduate certification in those days required 7 years of study, the same as a medical doctorate. By then she would have been 28 years old, and all the young men in her generation would already be married. Employment prospects for a woman were also negligible. A bargain was struck eventually and she was allowed to take a 3-month long art history course in Vienna, with all expenses paid. She enjoyed her stay there enormously, taking time out from her studies to go skiing and this is where she met my father.

They were very impressed by each other and shortly after married to the families' great relief.

I was born when my mother was 28 years old. People thought at the time that she was far too old to have a baby, but of course she managed it perfectly well and my father promptly fell in love with me and me with him.

Lala Mama came to visit and to make sure that everything was going well.

I am not sure if my mother breastfed me but most likely a wet nurse was employed, as was the custom those days. Soon after I was weaned, Carola came to stay as an au pair. She previously

worked in Surrey and having acquired a perfectly upper class accent she taught me a bit of English before she returned to marry a British bobby. (a policeman)

Other family members

In Budapest, I used to go to visit my father's cousin Hilda and her painter husband Oszkár Schilling who lived nearby. that he and Hilda were close relatives, first cousins of my father. Aunt Hilda and her Husband Uncle Oszkar have fallen on hard times but would not accept any help from my father, so I went to both English and French conversation classes on a weekly basis and had a reasonable command of both when we later came to England . Oszkar introduced me to Vazarely, Szenes and Csaky whom he knew from his days in Paris.

She often spoke about her younger brother Béla Balázs⁶, who was by then quite famous, having written the libretto of Bluebeard's Castle, the music for which was written by the renowned composer Béla Bartók⁷.

Balázs also wrote theatre plays, film scripts and treatises on the nature of film. He co-wrote (with Carl Mayer⁸) and helped Leni Riefenstahl⁹ direct the film *Das Blaue Licht* (1932). Riefenstahl, who then went on to work closely with Hitler, later removed Balázs's and Mayer's names from the credits because they were Jewish.

Unfortunately, I never met Balázs as he lived and worked in Russia from 1933 to 1945. Nevertheless, I became great admirer of his plays, films and writings on film.

Balázs returned to Hungary after the war and founded his own film school. He received the Kossúth prize, acknowledging his achievements in the arts, in 1949. His portrait is now on Hungarian stamps. It is somewhat ironic that in his lifetime he was much better known and appreciated in Germany than in his native Hungary.

My aunt, Klári Kovacs née Klara Biro

My mother Magda and Klári were devoted sisters, though very different in character, with perhaps a little rivalry between them.

⁶ Herbert Bauer, Balázs (1884-1949) was a Hungarian-Jewish film critic, writer and poet

⁷ Béla Bartók (1881-1945) is considered, alongside Liszt, as Hungary's greatest composer

⁸ Carl Mayer (1894-1944) was an Austrian-Jewish scriptwriter best known for the screenplays he wrote for films directed by F. W. Murnau

⁹ Leni Riefenstahl (1902-2003) was a German film director best known for her work on Hitler's propaganda films such as *Triumph of the Will* (1935)



Cardinal Eugenio Pacelli in a motorcade in Budapest in 1938 with Regent Miklos Horthy. Shortly after his visit Pacelli became Pope Pius XII

Agathe with motorcade 1938

Klári was like my grandmother, lively, positive and a bit dumpy for her age. She married quite young, to Sanyi (Kovacs Sándor) an ambitious young businessman with great prospects. They travelled all over the world, thereby avoiding the troubles awaiting us in Europe. Their son George, now 88, is still in perfect health and mind. He has three daughters and 11 grandchildren, all boys, now all grown up. They managed to avoid the horrors of war in Europe by moving abroad, first to Milan, where George attended a Jesuit day school and then moved to Canada where they bought a farm house while my uncle Sanyi worked for an international firm dealing mainly with farm machinery.

Klári a spoilt girl from a middle-class Hungarian-Jewish family had to run a farm in a remote area of Canada. It was very difficult for her.

She raised chickens commercially, which was a hard, competitive business. I believe she had the novel idea of increasing the egg production by playing music to the chickens, and apparently, they had a distinct preference for Mozart. George worked on the farm as well as going to school and learnt to drive a tractor at an incredibly early age as there were no rules of what you could do on private land. He and Klári were alone quite a lot, while Sanyi was travelling on business.

George was bright but not outstanding in school, so it was decided not to send him to university, which he has regretted all his life, despite the fact that he had a very successful business career. He insisted that his three girls should be university-trained and well-qualified. His father had also reached the top echelons in business without a degree, although I understand, Sanyi and his brother Laci attended commercial school in Hungary, which would now be called business school. This at the time did not have the same cache as a university degree.

Klári and Sanyi moved back to Europe after the war. They first moved to Lille, then to San Remo, Italy, and then to Clarens near Montreux, where they had a marvellous flat overlooking Lake Geneva. I visited them several times, once when my son Sylvan was a small boy. Sanyi did not take to retirement easily and bossed Klári around, bickering about trivial things mercilessly, while reading a lot and listening to music, usually in the privacy of his car. He died aged 84.

Klári then learnt to drive in her mid-70s and it was not easy to pass a test at her age. She took us touring in Switzerland and the south of France and showed us the wonderful landscape, museums and churches. She travelled to see us in England and

to see George and his family in Canada. She also found time to assemble her wartime diaries, based on entries made when she was 15 years old. This diary was later translated by George into English, and he also gave it a historical background. This is where most of my information comes from regarding this period.

Klári died age 93 in a luxurious private hospital in Montreux. Her health insurance had just run out and the always practical and pragmatic Swiss assumed that she would not like it in more modest surroundings and so she was given large doses of morphine. She was perfectly aware of what was going on and said goodbye to everyone. The funeral was packed by her many friends and relatives. George and his wife Anne stayed with her for her last three months and helped wind up the household afterwards. To show her independence of spirit, she wanted her ashes to be sprinkled over the lake, at her favourite point near her flat, but Anne, who looked after her so kindly for years, but who was ever a realist, would have nothing to do with this.

I believe Klári was afraid that Sanyi would keep bossing her about beyond the grave, a sentiment I can almost sympathize with.

In her will, Klári allowed me to choose objects from her flat. Apart from the three pieces of Bohemian Glass and textiles, I chose an early edition of the Larousse dictionary and encyclopaedia, with exquisite engravings, which came from her father's collection. She gave me during her life-time her wonderful collection of embroidery, from Yugoslavia, Hungary, Greece and Transylvania, I still have individual pieces displayed in my house, and I have used them in my art work several times. These objects take one into a strange world of peasants and gypsies and their festivities and ceremonial occasions. The same applies to the collection of Bohemian Glass, wisely purchased at knock down prices because of some imperfection.

During the summer camps organized by my art college I got interested in similar workmanship in villages in Hungary, where the so-called writing women painted the interiors of their small, cube-like thatched houses with the most wonderful curving branches and lianas, birds, butterflies, and flowers.

They painted in egg tempera, which has proved to be one of the most long-lasting media throughout history. It was not just their art that was of interest. The ground breaking modern composers Béla Bartók and Zoltán Kodály¹⁰ collected the music of these

¹⁰ Zoltán Kodály (1882-1967) was a distinguished Hungarian composer who wrote a thesis on Hungarian folk song

peasant and gypsy communities, fascinated with their strange oriental rhythms and peculiar pentatonic scales.

Another Klári

Before her death, Klári recommended that we should look after the other Kovacs Klári, her sister-in-law, wife of Sanyi's brother Laci. She had severe diabetes and as a result was often in and out of hospitals. She was childless, having only a niece, who lived in the USA and could not visit very often.

And so, it happened that we visited this charming and very bright old lady quite regularly. When she died, she left us a substantial part of her estate to help us with the education of our son.

Her story is also interesting and worth telling.

She came from a wealthy family, was bright and intelligent with a heart-warming smile, a pretty face, good figure, but she had a hunchback. These days, this could have been disguised with a shawl in a variety of ways, but then according to the norms of the day she wore a twin set or a blouse with a cardigan and a single row of pearls, which exposed her deformity and hid nothing. Nevertheless, Laci married her, obviously for her money and almost immediately installed his mistress on the floor directly below their apartment house. He felt guilty and went to a psychoanalyst, but afterwards everything continued as before. Poor Klári must have been aware of this, but suffered in silence; her money paid for it all.

After the 1956 Hungarian uprising, they decided to flee the country after most of the family assets were confiscated by the communist regime and they faced persecution.

They came to London and bought a beautiful house with a huge garden near my mother in North London.

Laci had a modest but respectable job as an accountant, while Klári learned the architectural drafting system, which was devilishly difficult to master but she was very well paid. Now this system is obsolete owing to computer software which became widely available and made many extremely clever people redundant.

Belatedly Laci began to realize the outstanding qualities and inner beauty of his wife and almost sanctified her to the embarrassment of all their friends, although by then any physical contact must have been ruled out as he became ill and died soon after. Klári continued with her social life and held bridge parties with tea and cakes and she and her friends got so good at the game, that one of them became grand master and turned professional at the age of 86 or so. Klári started a new career being invited and paid for by cruise liners to play with the passengers. She died a

couple of years later from diabetes.

The third sibling of Sanyi's family was Elsa, a tragic figure with a thousand fine wrinkles on her face.

She lived in Budapest, near my piano teacher, the famous Annie Fischer¹¹.

See: www.independent.co.uk/news/people/obituary-annie-fischer-1616335.html

I went to visit Elsa with the intention of painting her. She always sat motionless in her kitchen, with a photo of her beautiful young daughter Eva, shown dressed in shorts and tennis shoes, on the mantelpiece. Eva was abducted while walking on the street in 1944 and was taken to Auschwitz where she was gassed. I believe Elsa's husband also perished in the Holocaust. Someone denounced them. This, tragically, was a relatively frequent occurrence during those terrible days.

¹¹ Annie Fischer (1914-1995) was a Hungarian-Jewish pianist. She fled the country for Sweden in 1940 but returned to Budapest in 1946 and lived there until her death